Would You Buy That? Tone, Product Type, and Variance's Impact on Purchase Intent

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Motivation: Review tone and product type shape purchase decisions

- Negative reviews of utilitarian products are shown to be more diagnostic than reviews for hedonic products (Sen & Lerman, 2007).
- Emotions in negative reviews reduce the impact of a negative review for utilitarian products (Kim & Gupta, 2012)
- **However, we do not yet know how these factors work together with rating variance (low vs. high).**

Hypothesis: Review tone should affect utilitarian products more, especially under low variance

- **H1:** For a utilitarian product, a functional review tone will have lower purchase intent and attitude towards the product compared to an emotional review tone. This effect does not exist for a hedonic product.
- **H2a:** This effect is moderated by variance in ratings.
- **H2b:** There is a significant interaction in case of low variance in ratings, but this interaction does not exist for high variance in ratings.

Procedure: Participants evaluated reviews under random assignment

1. Completed Institutional Review Board application (2328129).
2. Pre-registration on AsPredicted.
3. Steps involved for participants:
   a. Self-selected themselves for the study.
   b. Read the consent form and agreed to participate.
   c. Randomly assigned to one of eight conditions.
   d. Viewed instructions and stimuli.
   e. Answered questions regarding:
      i. Purchase intent
      ii. Attitude toward product
      iii. The influence of star ratings and written reviews

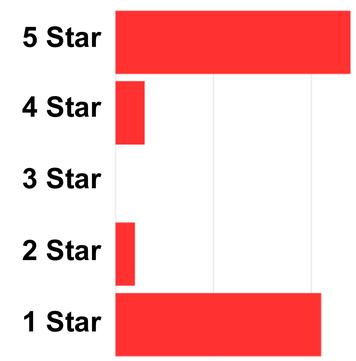
Study Design: Rating variance, product type, and review tone differ across conditions

Star rating distribution:
high vs. low variance

Product type:
hedonic vs. utilitarian

Written review tone:
emotional vs. functional

Star Ratings (High Variance):



Reviews (Hedonic x Emotional):

"This perfume **feels so energizing**. It instantly wakes up my senses and gives me a **burst of happiness** the moment I spray it!"

"**This makes me mad!** I keep checking and get nothing, **just pure frustration**. It feels like it vanishes on me."

Results: No interaction under low variance, but a three-way interaction influences purchase intent

Number of participants: 359

H1: Product Type x Review Tone (Low Variance Only) (Two-Way ANOVA)

We **fail to reject the null**. Review tone and product type did not interact to influence evaluations in low-variance settings (F = 1.610, p = .205 for attitude; F = 1.660, p = .198 for purchase intent).

H2: Product Type x Review Tone x Variance (Three-Way ANOVA)

We **reject the null for purchase intent but not for attitude**. Review tone, product type, and variance interacted to influence purchase intent (F = 4.288, p = .039), but marginally for attitude (F = 3.562, p = .059; controlling for gender). The results remain similar in direction and significance even with covariates not included.

Purchase Intent

Variance	Product Type	Review Tone	Mean	Std. Error
Low	Utilitarian	Functional	3.373	.152
		Emotional	3.132	.153
	Hedonic	Functional	3.434	.152
		Emotional	3.550	.151
High	Utilitarian	Functional	3.073	.153
		Emotional	3.371	.153
	Hedonic	Functional	3.655	.152
		Emotional	3.416	.152

Discussion: Findings contradict prior research and call for further investigation

Based on previous literature, we expected functional tone to lower purchase intent and attitude for utilitarian products under low variance (Kim & Gupta, 2012; Sen & Lerman, 2007). But we failed to find any interaction.

We found a significant three-way interaction for purchase intent. However, the direction of this interaction was not as expected. For hedonic products, we found emotional review tone was rated higher under low variance, which was opposite under high. This indicates that review tone and rating variance matter more for hedonic products than previously thought, requiring marketers to pay closer attention to how reviews of these products are presented. These results being contrary to previous research, question the reliability of previous findings and necessitate investigation into this in future research.

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References

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